



ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION
UNION PANAFRICAIN DES ETUDIANTS
UNIÃO DOS ESTUDANTES DE TODA A ÁFRICA
اتحاد طلاب عموم إفريقيا



Ministry of Foreign Affairs
Republic of Ghana

ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION

INAUGURATION AND HONOURS CEREMONY 2026

Under the Distinguished Patronage of
H.E. John Dramani Mahama,
President of the Republic of Ghana

THEME:

Reimagining Africa's Education Future:
Students as Partners in Reform and Delivery

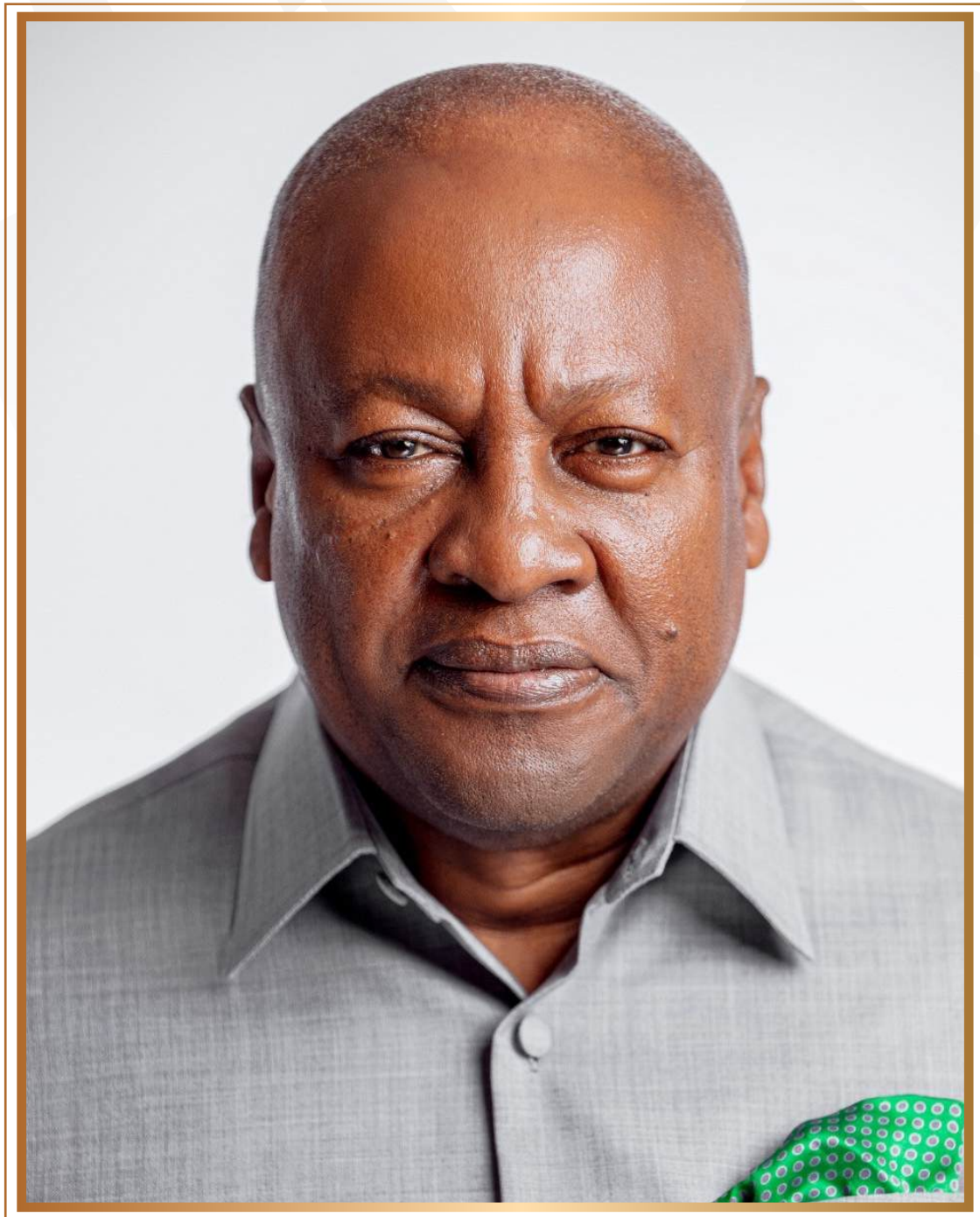


30 JANUARY
2026



CONFERENCE AUDITORIUM,
MINISTRY OF FOREIGN
AFFAIRS, ACCRA-GHANA

SPECIAL GUEST OF HONOUR



H.E. John Dramani Mahama
President of the Republic of Ghana

DISTINGUISHED HOST



Hon. Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa
Minister, Ministry of Foreign Affairs
The Republic of Ghana

SPECIAL HONOUREE



H.E. Dr. Mohamed Ibn Chambas
African Union High Representative
for Silencing the Guns

2022- 2025 AASU LEADERSHIP



Varney Alieu Jarsey
President
Liberia



Peter Kwasi Kodjie
Secretary General
Ghana



El Hadj Hussein Tapily
Vice President for West Africa
Côte D' Ivoire



Esther Ndeme Assiene
Vice President for Central Africa
Cameroon



Misheck Kakonde
Vice President for Southern Africa
Zambia



Mohamedali Abbobaker
Mohamed Elsafi
Vice President for East Africa
Sudan



Moustapha Sidi
Vice President for North Africa
Mauritania



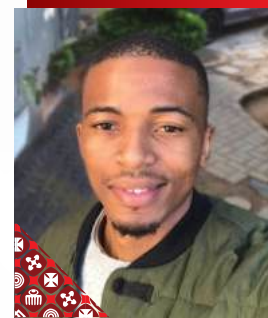
Ericson Ocante IÉ
Exec. Com. Member West Africa
Guinea Bissau



Gerard Musabanganji Male
Exec. Com. Member East Africa
Burundi



Mpaki Sah Phalek Schadrak
Exec. Com. Member Central Africa
Gabon



Tlotlo Madisa
Exec. Com. Member Southern Africa
Botswana



Juliet Tsepang Khumalo
Deputy Secretary-General
Lesotho



Angel Mbuthia
Secretary for Gender and
International Relations
Kenya



Emad Ahmed Nasir
Abu Isaynah
Secretary for Education and
Students Rights
Libya



Eustache Ndayisaba
Secretary for Finance and
Administration
Rwanda



Ajavon Kokoe
Vanéssa Augustine
Secretary for Press and Information
Togo

2026-2029 AASU LEADERSHIP



Enyinnaya Osikenye Osisiogu
President
Nigeria



Divine Edem Kwadzodeh
Secretary-General
Ghana



Maravilha Kapaia
Deputy President
Angola



Alistar Pfunye
Deputy Secretary-General
Zimbabwe



Jaber Maataoui
Vice President
for North Africa
Morocco



Rosália Djedjo
Vice President
for West Africa
Guinea-Bissau



Crésence Naomie Mban-ny Valentine Mugun Chepkoech
Vice President
for Central Africa
Cameroon



Valentine Mugun Chepkoech
Vice President
for East Africa
Kenya



Buthanani Thobela
Vice President
for Southern Africa
South Africa



Habiba Mohamed Abdallah
Executive Committee
Member for North Africa
Egypt



Oumu Sall
Executive Committee
Member for West Africa
Liberia



Benita Ndokolo Mfuke
Executive Committee
Member for Central Africa
DR Congo



Stellah Akur Garang
Executive Committee
Member for East Africa
South Sudan



Esther Gomani
Executive Committee
Member for Southern Africa
Malawi



Ben-Christ Trésor Saizonou
Secretary for Education &
Students' Rights
Benin



Amadou B. Jobarteh
Secretary for Press
& Information
The Gambia



Boago Dodo Chingapani
Secretary for Gender &
Affirmative Action
Botswana



Vanessa Kokoe Ajavon
Secretary for Finance
and Administration
Togo

WELCOME MESSAGE

On behalf of the All-Africa Students Union (AASU), it is with profound honour and a deep sense of responsibility that we welcome you to this historic Handing-Over, Inauguration, and Honours Ceremony. This occasion marks not only a transition in leadership but also a moment of collective reflection on the journey of Africa's student movement and its evolving role in shaping the continent's educational, democratic, and developmental future.

The peaceful transfer of leadership from the outgoing administration (2021–2025) to the 14th AASU leadership (2026–2029) affirms AASU's enduring commitment to constitutionalism, accountability, and institutional continuity. Over the past eight years, the Union has strengthened its policy relevance, expanded its programme reach, and deepened its engagement with governments, continental institutions, development partners, and student movements across Africa. Today's ceremony therefore serves as both a formal closure of one chapter and the opening of another, grounded in shared values and collective purpose.

This event also provides an opportunity to honour individuals, institutions, and partners whose contributions have advanced the cause of African students and reinforced the principle that students are not passive beneficiaries of reform, but active partners in shaping education systems and public policy. Through these honours, AASU reaffirms the importance of service, solidarity, and Pan-African cooperation in advancing inclusive and sustainable development.

We are grateful to the Government and People of the Republic of Ghana for hosting this important continental gathering and for their continued support to African youth and student engagement. As we inaugurate the new leadership, we look ahead with confidence, mindful of the challenges before us and inspired by the opportunities to deepen impact. We invite all stakeholders present to join us in reaffirming a shared commitment to an Africa where education empowers, leadership serves, and students remain central to the continent's transformation.

ABOUT THE ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) is the recognised Continental umbrella body representing students across all levels of education - from basic through to higher education - throughout Africa and the African diaspora. Established in 1972, AASU has, for over five decades, served as the collective institutional voice of African students, advancing students' rights, promoting democratic governance within education systems, and contributing to the broader development discourse at national, Continental, and global levels. With representation in fifty-four (54) African countries through eighty-five (85) national student unions and a constituency exceeding 300 million students, the Union occupies a unique and strategic position within Africa's education, youth, and development architecture. In recognition of its historic role, the United Nations in the year 2000 awarded AASU a Certificate of Merit for its contribution to advancing students' rights and the democratisation of education across the Continent.

See: <http://www.un.org/press/en/2000/20000410.dev2241.doc.html>.

Since 1987, the Permanent Secretariat of AASU has been hosted by the Republic of Ghana, through the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. This longstanding arrangement has provided critical diplomatic, institutional, and logistical support, enabling AASU to function effectively as a continental organisation.

At its establishment in 1972, the Union played an important role in the struggle against colonialism in Africa and the ending of apartheid in South Africa. Today, AASU is at the forefront of the fights for equal access to quality education, quality assurance in higher education, harmonisation of higher education systems with key emphasis on the mobility of academics and comparability of qualifications, democratic governance, defending students' rights, promotion of gender equality and African culture, sustainable development, entrepreneurship, fostering of academic freedom, freedom of research and autonomy of higher institutions of learning, the promotion of peace and democratic values, and other noteworthy objectives.

The Union is wholly student-run and student-led, autonomous, representative, and operates according to democratic principles.

AASU's key strength lies in its diversity and numerical strength, which it employs as a bargaining tool to speak for the supreme interests of students at all times. The Union is made up of diverse students, regardless of their religion, gender, cultural background, political persuasion, ethnic origin or social standing.

OUR MISSION

To create among the broad masses of African peoples a sense of awareness of the challenges confronting the Continent and the need for students, as an integral part of their society, to be fully involved in all endeavours aimed at resolving them.

OUR VISION

To be the leading organisation in mobilising, co-coordinating and involving African students in all the efforts geared towards the socio-economic, political and cultural advancement of Africa.

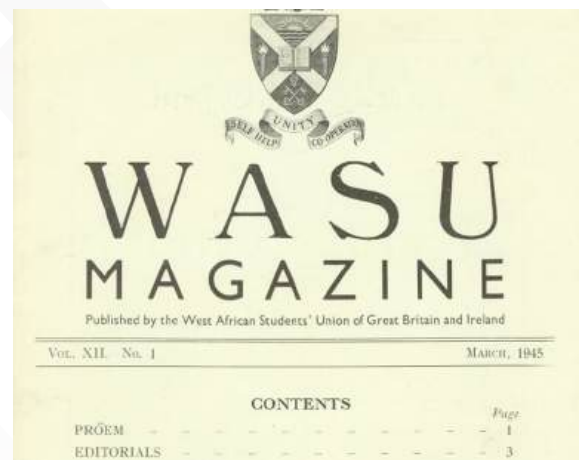
HISTORICAL MILESTONES OF THE ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION (AASU)

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) was founded in 1972 as a Pan-African platform to unite student movements across the continent and the African diaspora in the struggle for liberation, equity, and democratic participation in education and society. Its formation was rooted in the broader Pan-African movement and the recognition of students as a critical force in Africa's political, social, and intellectual transformation.

Founding and Early Consolidation (1972-1976)

AASU held its First Congress in 1972 at the University of Science and Technology (UST), now Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology (KNUST), in Kumasi, Ghana. Despite significant challenges in communication, transport, and resources, representatives from fewer than ten African countries convened, formally establishing the Union and setting the foundation for a continental student movement.

The Union expanded rapidly in its early years. The Second Congress was held in Dar es Salaam, Tanzania, in 1973, followed by the Third Congress in Alexandria, Egypt, in 1974. By the Fourth Congress in Accra, Ghana, in 1976, AASU had grown substantially, welcoming most National Students' Organisations across Africa as well as student wings of liberation movements, including the African National Congress (ANC) of South Africa and the South West Africa People's Organisation (SWAPO). During this period, AASU firmly positioned itself as a voice against colonialism, apartheid, and political repression.



Institutional Growth and Pan-African Solidarity (1980s-1990s)

The Sixth Congress, held in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, in 1982 marked a defining moment in AASU's history. At this Congress, June 16 was declared African Students' Day, commemorating the students who were killed, injured, or displaced during the 1976 Soweto Uprising in South Africa. This declaration cemented AASU's role as a moral and political custodian of Africa's student memory and resistance.

AASU continued to consolidate its presence through the Seventh Congress in Luanda, Angola, in 1987, and the Eighth Congress in Accra, Ghana, in 1992. These congresses strengthened continental coordination, expanded membership, and reinforced AASU's leadership role within African student movements during a period of political transition across many African states.

Challenges, Reorganisation, and Renewal (2000–2010s)

The Ninth Congress, held in Tripoli, Libya, in 2000, coincided with a period of internal organisational challenges. Disputes within the Secretariat and governance structures affected the Union's operations and slowed programme delivery. Following several unsuccessful attempts to convene a congress, the Tenth Congress was eventually held in Accra, Ghana, marking an important phase of reorganisation, reconciliation, and institutional renewal.

In the years that followed, AASU gradually rebuilt its structures, re-established its legitimacy among member unions, and refocused on programme-based engagement, advocacy, and partnerships at continental and global levels.



Transition to the 2026–2029 Leadership

The successful conduct of AASU's 14th Elective Congress in December 2025 marked another milestone in the Union's democratic tradition. In accordance with its Constitution, AASU renewed its leadership through transparent and participatory elections, paving the way for the inauguration of a newly elected Executive Committee and Secretariat for the 2026–2029 term.

Today, AASU stands as the largest continental student organisation in Africa, representing tens of millions of students across linguistic, cultural, religious, and political divides. Its journey reflects resilience, renewal, and an enduring commitment to Pan-Africanism, democratic governance, and the principle that students are not passive beneficiaries of reform, but active partners in shaping Africa's education and development future.



Institutional Strengthening and Global Engagement (2015–2025)

From the mid-2010s onward, AASU entered a period of renewed relevance and expansion. The Union strengthened its engagement in education policy advocacy, student participation in quality assurance and governance, academic mobility and qualifications recognition, leadership and skills development, gender equity, climate action, and democratic governance.

During this period, AASU deepened strategic partnerships with the African Union, the United Nations system, governments, higher education institutions, and development partners. Its programme portfolio expanded significantly, reaching millions of students and youth across Africa and reinforcing its position as a credible continental interlocutor for student interests.



STRATEGIC PRIORITIES OF THE ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION

Our strategic approach is to address the crucial issues affecting African students and young people, as such, we have identified Seven (7) Strategic Priorities to guide our work at the Secretariat in accordance with the aims and objectives of the Union. AASU's Strategic Priorities are fully aligned to the UN and AU's development priorities as articulated in the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and Agenda 2063 respectively. In addition, these priorities complement the global efforts to build a relevant contemporary human capital, capable of fitting into the global citizen ecosystem.

The Seven (7) Strategic Priorities of the Union are:



KEY STATISTICS

300M+

Students represented across Africa, positioning AASU as the largest continental student platform on the continent

50M+

students and youth reached through our programmes and projects

85+

national student unions and associations, spanning Anglophone, Francophone, Lusophone, and Arabophone Africa.

40+

programmes and projects advancing students' and youth rights, leadership, and Pan-African cooperation

15+

project-based interventions

KEY AASU PROGRAMMES AND PROJECTS

Strategic Priority	Flagship Programme	Brief Description
 EDUCATION & STUDENTS' RIGHTS	Africa Quality Assurance Students Expert Pool (QASE)	Builds student capacity to participate in higher education quality assurance and accreditation processes.
	Education Enrolment Programme (EEP)	Supports access to formal education for vulnerable children and marginalised communities.
	SDG 4 Through Students' Eyes	Student-led monitoring of progress towards inclusive and equitable quality education in Africa.
	Africa Students' Day	Annual continental commemoration recognising student activism and Africa's student movement history.
 CAPACITY BUILDING	Student Leaders Training Programmes	Continental and regional leadership development initiatives for student leaders.
	Next Level Skills for Student Leaders	Advanced leadership, advocacy, and organisational capacity-building programme.
	African Student Entrepreneurs Summit (ASES)	Continental platform promoting student entrepreneurship, innovation, and enterprise.

Strategic Priority	Flagship Programme	Brief Description
 GENDER ADVOCACY	4.0 Skills & Digital Training Initiatives	Development of digital and future-ready skills for the Fourth Industrial Revolution.
	Keep A Girl in School (KAGIS)	Promotes retention and progression of girls in education across Africa.
	Girls in STEM	Encourages girls' participation in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics.
	Safe Spaces in Universities Project	Addresses sexual and gender-based violence and promotes safe learning environments.
	Young Women in Leadership	Builds leadership capacity and visibility of young women student leaders.
 ENVIRONMENT & CLIMATE ACTION	Transformative Climate Education Programme	Promotes climate literacy, justice, and youth engagement in climate action.
	Youth Climate Negotiators & Pre-COP Engagements	Prepares students and youth for participation in global climate policy processes.
	Eco-Ambassadors & Tree Planting Initiatives	Encourages environmental stewardship and community-based climate action.

Strategic Priority	Flagship Programme	Brief Description
 PAN-AFRICANISM & AFRICAN CULTURE	Africa Students and Youth Summit	Continental convening for policy dialogue, leadership development, and Pan-African solidarity.
	Africa Music, Arts and Cultural Exhibition (AMACE)	Celebrates African culture and creativity as tools for unity and engagement.
	Africa–Diaspora Student Connect	Fosters collaboration and exchange between African students and the global diaspora.
 MIGRATION & MOBILITY	Migrant Students Network Initiative	Supports integration, welfare, and representation of African international students.
	Students Advocating for Refugees	Promotes access to quality education for refugees and displaced learners.
	Student Mobility Advocacy Training	Strengthens student engagement in mobility governance and qualifications recognition.
 DEMOCRACY & GOOD GOVERNANCE	Africa Student Governance Index (ASGI)	Assesses effectiveness and accountability of student governance structures.
	Election Observation & Civic Engagement Initiatives	Supports student participation in democratic processes and civic education.
	Conflict Management & Peacebuilding Training	Equips youth with skills for dialogue, conflict prevention, and peaceful engagement.

HONOUR CONFERMENT – AASU CHAMPION FOR STUDENTS AS STRATEGIC PARTNERS IN AFRICA'S EDUCATION TRANSFORMATION

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) is proud to confer the title "AASU Champion for Students as Strategic Partners in Africa's Education Transformation" on His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, President of the Republic of Ghana. This honour recognises a leader whose career and public service reflect a deep commitment to education, inclusive development, and the empowerment of students and young people across the continent.

H.E. John Dramani Mahama has served Ghana in multiple leadership capacities, including as Member of Parliament, Vice-President, and President of the Republic, with a legacy of engagement in public policy and human development. His administration has consistently emphasised the importance of education as a foundation for national progress, including prioritising budgetary allocations to the sector and championing policies that expand access, equity, and quality for all children and youth. His leadership reflects a belief that education must be both inclusive and transformative, enabling students not merely to access learning but to shape the systems in which they participate.

In recognising President Mahama as an AASU Champion, the Union affirms the central principle that students are not passive beneficiaries of reform, but strategic partners in the design, governance, and delivery of education solutions across Africa. This honour acknowledges H.E. Mahama's contributions to advancing this principle at national, regional and global levels and highlights his alignment with AASU's mission to see African students actively involved in shaping educational policy and practice. It also celebrates his ongoing commitment to equitable education and his advocacy for resource investment that broadens opportunities for all learners. As AASU inaugurates its new leadership, this conferment symbolises a shared commitment to sustained collaboration between student movements and public institutions in realising Africa's education aspirations.

INAUGURATION AND HONOURS CEREMONY PROGRAMME OUTLINE

TIME	PROGRAMME SEGMENT	ACTIVITY	RESPONSIBLE / LEAD
1:00 PM - 2:45 PM	Arrival & Seating of Guests	Arrival of invited guests and dignitaries	Protocol Team
		Arrival of Diplomatic Corps and Special Guests	Protocol Team
3:00 PM	Arrival of Special Guest of Honour	Arrival of H.E. John Dramani Mahama	State Protocol
3:05 PM	Opening Formalities	Call to Order	Master of Ceremonies
3:05 PM - 3:10 PM		Opening Prayers (Christian & Islamic)	Reverend Minister & Imam
3:10 PM - 3:12 PM		National Anthem of Ghana	All Standing
3:12 PM - 3:15 PM		All-Africa Students Union Anthem	AASU Technical Team
3:15 PM - 3:20 PM	Welcome & Institutional Context	Welcome Address	Jemilatu Mamshie Bawa Chief Operating Officer, AASU
3:20 PM - 3:30 PM		AASU History & Institutional Overview (Documentary)	AASU Technical Team
3:30 PM - 3:35 PM		Cultural Performance	Cultural Troupe
3:35 PM - 3:45 PM	Inauguration Segment	Valedictory Address	Outgoing Secretary-General, AASU
3:45 PM - 3:50 PM		Presentation of Newly Elected Executive Committee & Secretariat	Outgoing Secretary-General
3:50 PM - 4:00 PM		Administration of Oaths of Office	Judge of the Superior Courts
4:00 PM - 4:10 PM		Inaugural Address (2026-2029)	Secretary-General, AASU
4:10 PM - 4:15 PM	Honours & Recognitions	Posthumous Honour to Late AASU President	Secretary-General, AASU
4:15 PM - 4:20 PM		Honour to Outgone Secretary-General	President, AASU

INAUGURATION AND HONOURS CEREMONY PROGRAMME OUTLINE

TIME	PROGRAMME SEGMENT	ACTIVITY	RESPONSIBLE / LEAD
4:20 PM - 4:25 PM	Honours & Recognitions	Honour to H.E. Dr. Mohammed Ibn Chambas	Minister of Foreign Affairs; AASU President; AASU Secretary-General
4:25 PM - 4:30 PM		Citation: Government & People of the Republic of Ghana	AASU President; Outgone AASU Secretary General; AASU Secretary General
4:30 PM - 4:40 PM		Special Remarks	Hon Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa Minister for Foreign Affairs, Republic of Ghana
4:40 PM - 4:45 PM		Conferment: Grand Patron of AASU	President; Secretary-General; AASU H.E. Dr. Mohamed Ibn Chambas
4:45 PM - 4:50 PM		Conferment: AASU Champion for Students as Strategic Partners	President; Secretary-General; AASU H.E. Dr. Mohamed Ibn Chambas
4:50 PM - 5:10 PM	Special Address	Address by the Special Guest of Honour	H.E. John Dramani Mahama
5:10 PM - 5:20 PM	Closing Formalities	Closing Address & Vote of Thanks	President, AASU
5:20 PM - 5:30 PM		Official Group Photographs	Protocol & Media
5:30 PM - 5:40 PM		Closing Prayers & Formal Close	MC / Reverend Minister / Imam
5:40 PM onwards	Departure	Departure of Special Guest of Honour & Dignitaries	Protocol Team
6:00 PM - onwards	Dinner Reception	High-Level Diplomatic Dinner & Networking	AASU & State Protocol Teams
		Toasts, Dinner Service & Informal Engagements	

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) expresses its profound appreciation to all institutions, partners, and individuals whose commitment and collaboration have contributed to the growth, impact, and continuity of the Union over the years. This Handing-Over, Inauguration, and Honours Ceremony stands as a collective achievement, made possible through shared vision, solidarity, and sustained support.

AASU extends its deepest gratitude to the Government and People of the Republic of Ghana for their longstanding partnership and hospitality, and for hosting the AASU Continental Secretariat in Accra. The Government of Ghana's consistent support for youth and student engagement has provided a stable institutional home for the Union and strengthened its ability to operate effectively at the continental level. This partnership reflects Ghana's enduring commitment to Pan-Africanism, education, and the empowerment of Africa's youth.

We also acknowledge with sincere appreciation all continental, international, development, civil society, private sector, and media partners who have worked alongside AASU in advancing students' rights, leadership development, education reform, climate action, and Pan-African cooperation. Your trust, technical support, and collaboration have enabled the Union to translate advocacy into meaningful programmes and lasting impact across Africa.

Special recognition is extended to the AASU Secretariat and staff, whose professionalism, dedication, and resilience have sustained the day-to-day operations of the Union and ensured institutional continuity through periods of growth and transition. Your commitment remains the backbone of AASU's work.

Finally, AASU pays tribute to the outgoing Executive Committee and leadership of the 2021–2025 administration for their exemplary service, vision, and stewardship. Their collective efforts strengthened the Union's policy relevance, programme reach, and institutional credibility, laying a solid foundation for the incoming leadership. As AASU enters a new chapter, we do so with gratitude for the past, confidence in the present, and optimism for the future of Africa's student movement.

OUR PARTNERS



Government of the Republic of Ghana



United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization



ASSOCIATION OF AFRICAN UNIVERSITIES
ASSOCIATION DES UNIVERSITES AFRICAINES
الاتحاد الجامعات الافريقية



European Union



Oxfam International



The UN Global Fund for Education in Emergencies and Protracted Crises



Unione delle Università del Mediterraneo
Mediterranean Universities Union
Union des Universités de la Méditerranée
اتحاد الجامعات المتوسطية



Mobilizing the youth for AFCTA



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اتحاد طلاب عموم إفريقيا



Ministry of Foreign Affairs
Republic of Ghana

AASU INAUGURATION AND HONOURS CEREMONY 2026

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